vote on the basis of caste and religion?
People will mostly continue to vote on caste and religion. I do not doubt this reality, but the Congress wants to challenge it by creating a new paradigm. Women are almost 50 per cent of the population, and by far the strongest political force in the state—in the nation, in fact—if they become aware of their collective capacity to bring about change. Our party is making a beginning, laying the foundation for a new discourse. We are telling women they're the custodians of the future: awaken to your power, join forces, assert your rights.

Q. What was the rationale for giving Unnao rape victim's kin tickets? You also have social activists, ASHA workers.... Will old party leaders keen on those seats support the new candidates?
The reason for choosing such people is to empower them. Political empowerment is the real tool for change. The Unnao candidate's daughter is widely reported to have been allegedly raped by the local BJP MLA, her husband was taken into custody with the collusion of the BJP government and allegedly beaten to death, her brother-in-law is languishing in jail, denied permission to come home to complete the last rites of five deceased kin. Her daughter's lawyer was killed in an accident allegedly orchestrated by the same MLA. Her sister-in-law and niece died in that accident and the rape victim herself would have been left for dead had it not been for statewide protests led by our party. We are telling her—and to all victims of unimaginable injustice—that we will support you to become an MLA yourself. We will help you claim the power used to destroy your life, so that no one can ever use it to trample all over you again.

In the case of other activists and those who have fought similar battles, we are again sending a clear message: we believe the purpose of politics is to serve the public, fight for justice and empower the disempowered. Our party cadres are supporting these candidates in most areas; wherever there are hurt feelings, we're working to resolve them.

Q. Why is the Congress not following the '40 per cent women' formula in other states? CM Yogi flagged this too.
Beginnings such as these are made step by step. Like all big changes, this one too will take time to take hold. Mr Yogi and his party ask these questions not because they care for women's empowerment but because they are afraid of the call to action to women. They fully understand that if women rise and become aware of their rights and powers, they can change the course of India's politics. That's why they have done nothing but relentlessly attack women since we started this campaign, first with the women's marathons, then our Women's Manifesto and now our women leaders and candidates.

They have just released their first list of candidates...there are barely 10 women. They are misogynists with a narrow worldview who cannot, in their wildest imagination, accept women as equals. The BJP's idea of empowering women is handing them one free gas cylinder a year. They want to give them doles, not political space. We are challenging that idea. When it comes to women's issues, the BJP is predictable: it is now attacking one of our candidates using photos of her in a bikini! It exposes their anti-woman mindset even more.

> **"THE BJP'S IDEA OF EMPOWERING WOMEN IS TO HAND THEM ONE FREE GAS CYLINDER A YEAR. THEY WANT TO GIVE THEM DOLES, NOT POLITICAL SPACE"**

Q. Why did so many senior UP leaders leave, alleging that the "new UPCC functionaries" were not listening to them?
And why should the new UPCC functionaries listen only to them? The whole purpose of revamping the party organisation was to make it responsive to the grassroots. Allowing party workers and a broader local leadership to have a say in the organisational structure and the direction of our politics is essential for the party to grow in UP. For the first time in 30 years, we have an organisation that reaches the nyay and gram panchayat level. We have almost one lakh workers who have attended ideological and practical training workshops, we have cadres that can mobilise for massive rallies and, most importantly, we have relentlessly raised issues that matter to the public in the past two years. In fact, over 18,700 of them have been sent to jail by the BJP government over the past year and a half. It's no longer an organisation where anyone, including me, can randomly insert *chamcha*s and hangers-on into positions. It's gradually building itself on merit and representation.

Having said that, different people have left for different reasons. I cannot speak for them. When they were in our party, their opinions and wishes were valued. They also had the privilege of holding posts and being given opportunities many other honest and equally hard-working people in our party might not have got as they lacked the same level of access and opportunity. Perhaps all this was not enough for them.

Q. Why is there no pre-poll alliance this time...are you focusing on 2024?
We are working very hard, have a strong campaign that raises issues that resonate with the public, and are fighting this election with full focus. I do not believe it's a question of either/or...2024 follows 2022. Whether organisational or electoral, the work we do now will provide a strong foundation for 2024 as well.

On alliances, I have repeatedly stated that the Congress is open to working with other parties. Akhileshji is aware of this. I also reached out to Mayawatiji and spoke with her several times. We are, however, happy to be fighting on our own as this will give our party the opportunity to rebuild itself.

Q. How many seats are you expecting in UP? What do you predict for Punjab, Goa, Manipur and Uttarakhand?
I'm not a fortune-teller unfortunately, so I do not believe in making predictions. We are running solid campaigns, speaking up for the right things in each state and hope people respond positively. ■